7V7 FORMATION GUIDE

3-2-1

A starting shape, four playing principles and a job for every position.

INSIDE

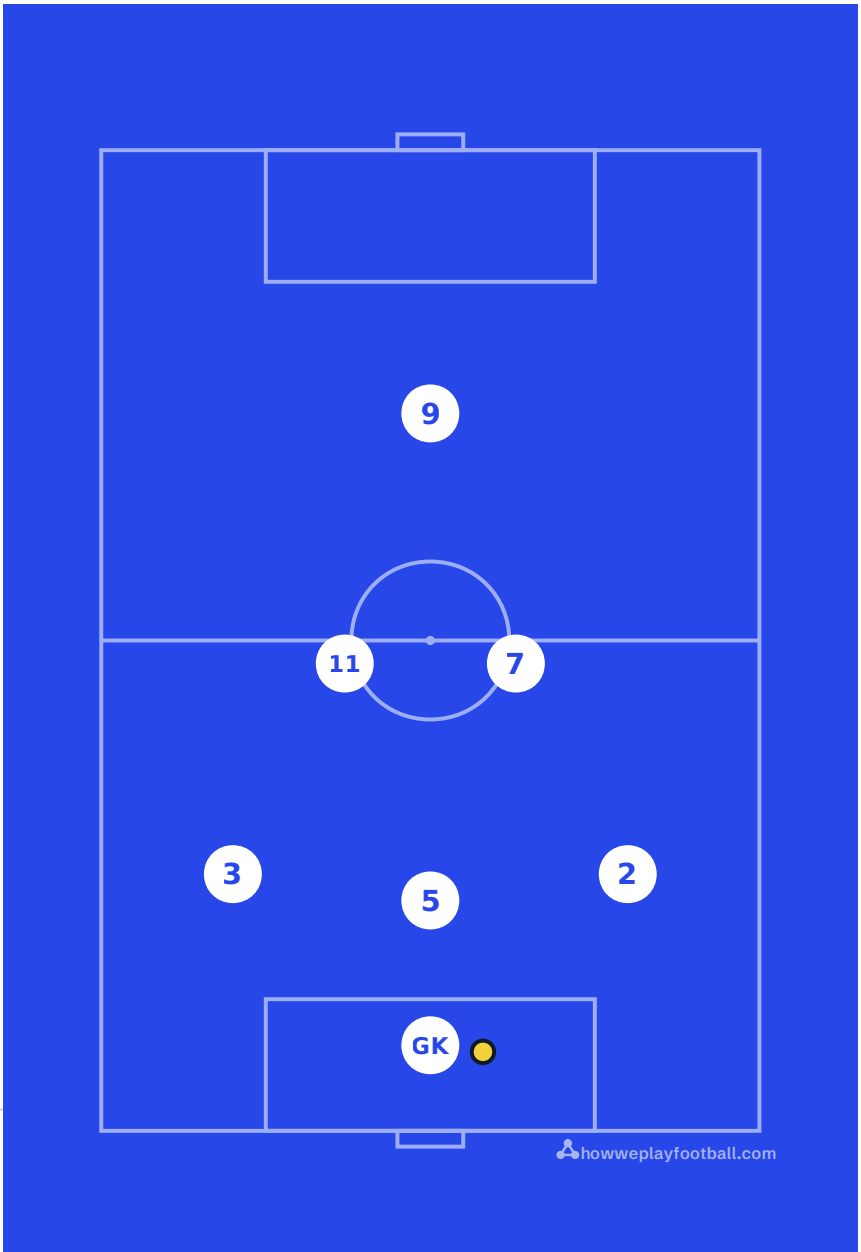
01 Starting shape

02 Four playing principles

03 A job for every player

04 Coaching reminders

THE FORMATION IS OUR STARTING PICTURE. IT ISN'T WHERE WE HAVE TO STAND.



INTRODUCTION

WELCOME

The 3-2-1 gives us three defenders, two midfielders and a striker, supported by our goalkeeper. It's another way to organise 7v7: the back three can protect one another, but the team must still find width and make sure our striker isn't left on their own. The answer isn't to tell children to stand still. It's to give them four small decisions they can practise and change as they learn.

WHO IT'S FOR

Volunteer grassroots football coaches and parents looking for a shared starting picture for 7v7.

The shape helps us explain jobs. Players should still have opportunities to try different roles.

HOW TO USE IT

- Learn the starting shape.
- Pick one of the four principles to talk about.
- Give each player a short, useful question.
- Use the online diagrams when you want to see movement.

IN THIS GUIDE

01 Starting shape

02 Four playing principles

03 A job for every player

04 Coaching reminders and notes

A CLEAR SHAPE. SIMPLE DECISIONS. ROOM FOR CHILDREN TO LEARN.

HOW TO READ THIS GUIDE

READING THE DIAGRAMS

We always attack up the page. These pictures capture a moment, not a fixed running lane.

8

OUR PLAYER

A blue player with a number.

THEM

A player from the opposition.

BALL

Where the ball is in this moment.

MOVEMENT

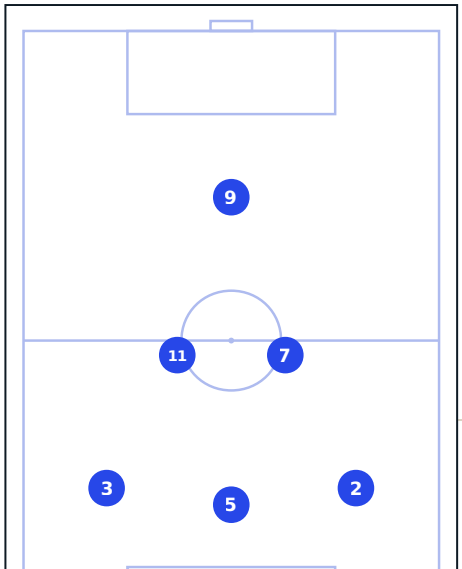
A solid arrow shows a possible run.

PASS

A broken arrow can show a pass.

SPACE

A highlighted area draws your eye to a decision.



7V7 · 3-2-1

A STARTING SHAPE, NOT A FIXED PLAN FOR EVERY SECOND.

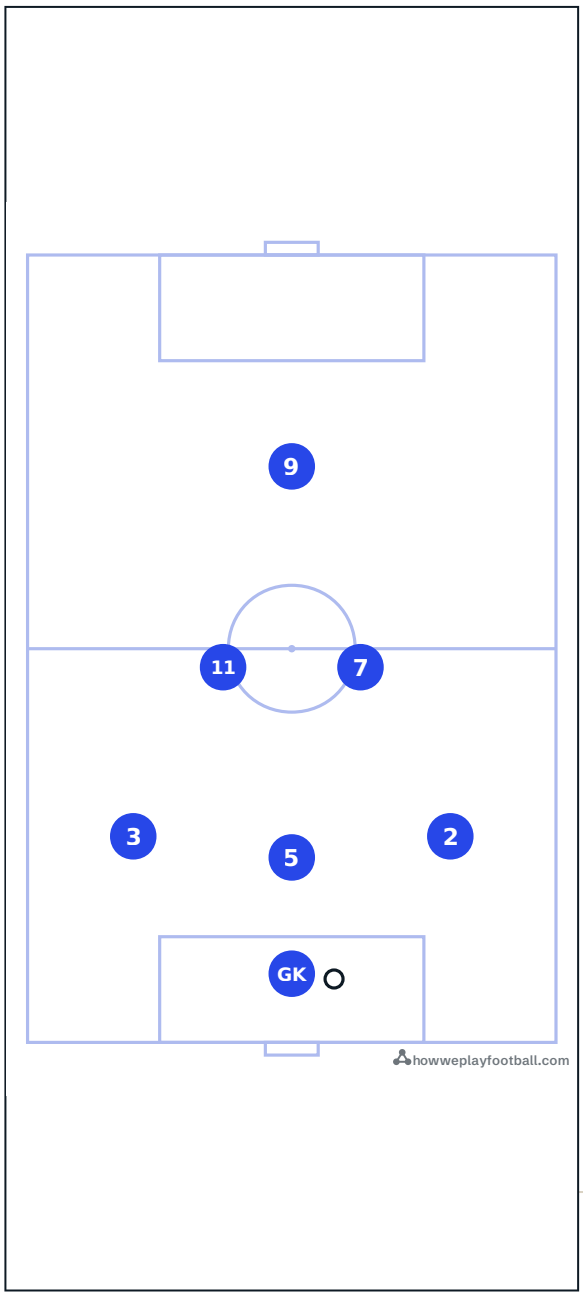
The numbers identify jobs in the drawings. They do not lock children into one position.

Illustrative diagrams, not pitch plans drawn to scale.

CHAPTER 01 · THE STARTING PICTURE

STARTING SHAPE

The 3-2-1 gives us three defenders, two midfielders and a striker, supported by our goalkeeper. It's another way to organise 7v7: the back three can protect one another, but the team must still find width and make sure our striker isn't left on their own. The answer isn't to tell children to stand still. It's to give them four small decisions they can practise and change as they learn.



THIS SHAPE GIVES US

- three defenders supporting one another behind the ball
- a chance for an outside defender to provide width
- a midfield pair that can support at different heights
- a striker who can come short or threaten forward space

REMEMBER

- simple team decisions that balance support and protection

SAME STARTING SHAPE. DIFFERENT DECISIONS AS THE BALL MOVES.

7v7 · The 3-2-1 · Indicative player starting positions

CHAPTER 01 · THE STARTING PICTURE

A JOB FOR EVERYONE

The numbers help us talk about where to start. The actual decision depends on the ball, the opposition and our teammates.

GK GOALKEEPER

Look first. Give us a start.

5 CENTRE-BACK

Connect and protect

3 · 2 OUTSIDE DEFENDERS

Defend your side. Know when to join in.

11 · 7 THE TWO MIDFIELDERS

Different angles, together

9 STRIKER

Show short or stretch the pitch

THE BIG PICTURE

Each position has a simple job. The four principles help those jobs fit together.

CHAPTER 02 · HOW WE PLAY

FOUR PRINCIPLES

Small decisions the whole team can recognise and talk about.

01 USE THE BACK THREE

Give the goalkeeper clear choices instead of three players in one line. A centre-back and two outside defenders help create different passing angles when the ball starts with our goalkeeper.

“Can our keeper see a pass?”

02 ONE GOES, TWO PROTECT

Find width without leaving our centre-back alone. An outside defender can support play on the wing if the other two defenders are ready to protect us.

“One goes. Where are the other two?”

03 ONE SHORT, ONE HIGHER

Two midfielders can give us different passing distances. One midfielder offers a shorter pass while the other can support the striker on a higher line.

“Can we give two different passes?”

04 DON'T LEAVE NINE ALONE

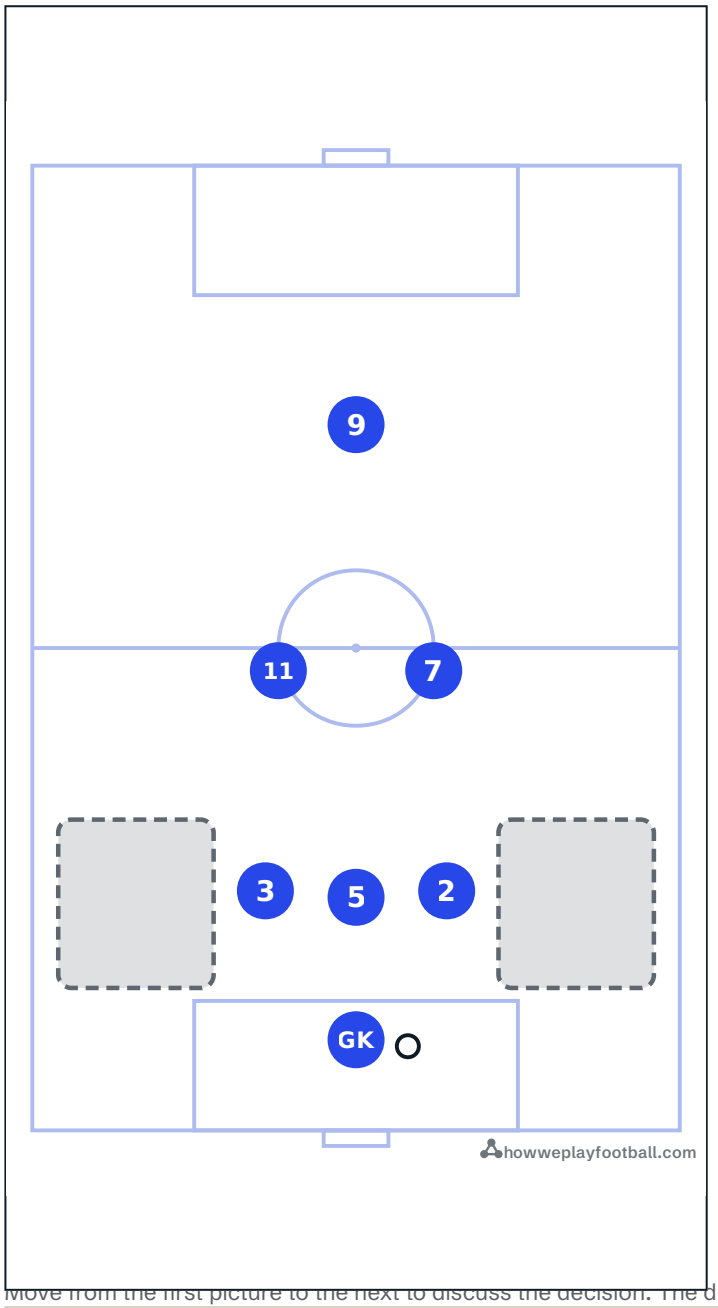
Give our striker somebody to play with. One midfielder moves near enough to link with the striker, with another option behind and the defenders connected.

“Who's close enough to help nine?”

CHAPTER 02 · PRINCIPLE 01 OF 04

USE THE BACK THREE

Give the goalkeeper clear choices instead of three players in one line. A centre-back and two outside defenders help create different passing angles when the ball starts with our goalkeeper.



PICTURE 1 OF 2

NO EASY ANGLES

When the three defenders crowd the same channel, our goalkeeper sees fewer clear passing options.

SAY IT ON THE TOUCHLINE

“CAN OUR KEEPER SEE A PASS?”

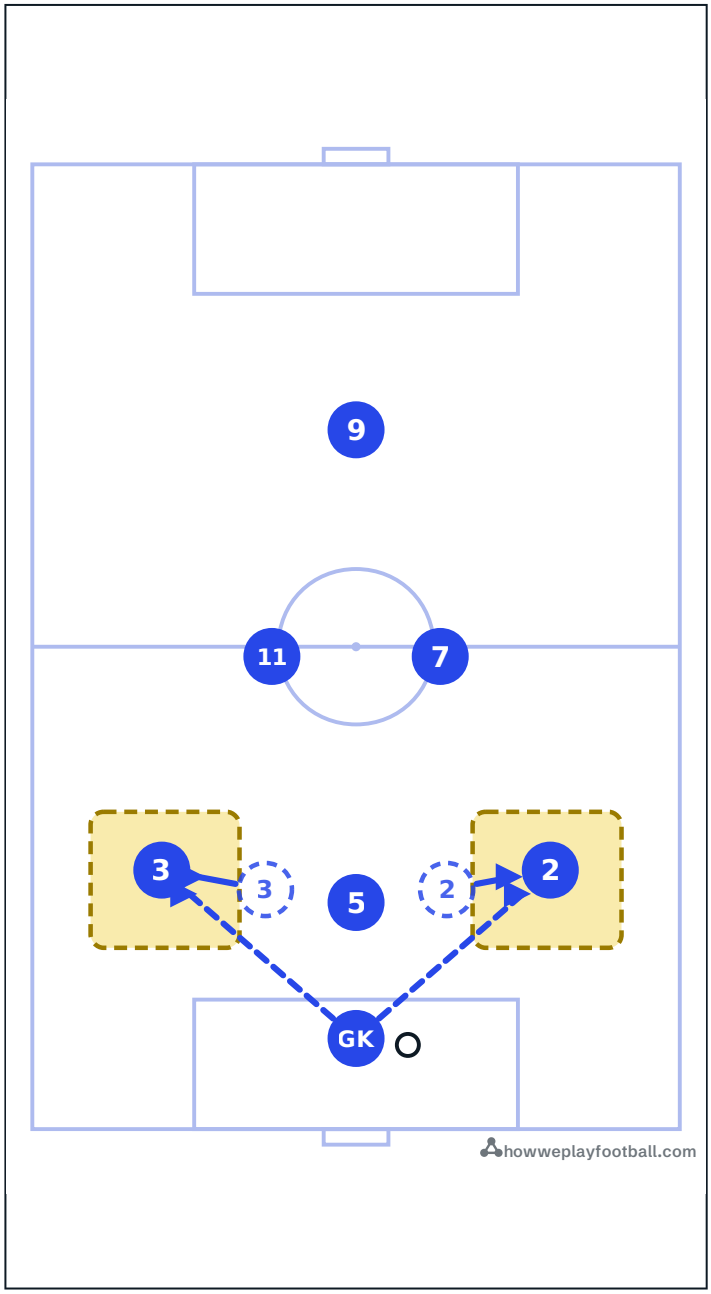
Three players is not automatically three options. Do not force a risky short pass.

Move from the first picture to the next to discuss the decision. The drawings are illustrative, not fixed moves.

CHAPTER 02 · PRINCIPLE 01 OF 04

LOOK FOR THIS

Three things to notice when your players make this decision.



PICTURE 2 OF 2

OPEN THE PICTURE

3 and 2 find passing angles outside, while 5 offers support through the middle. Pick a safe pass.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

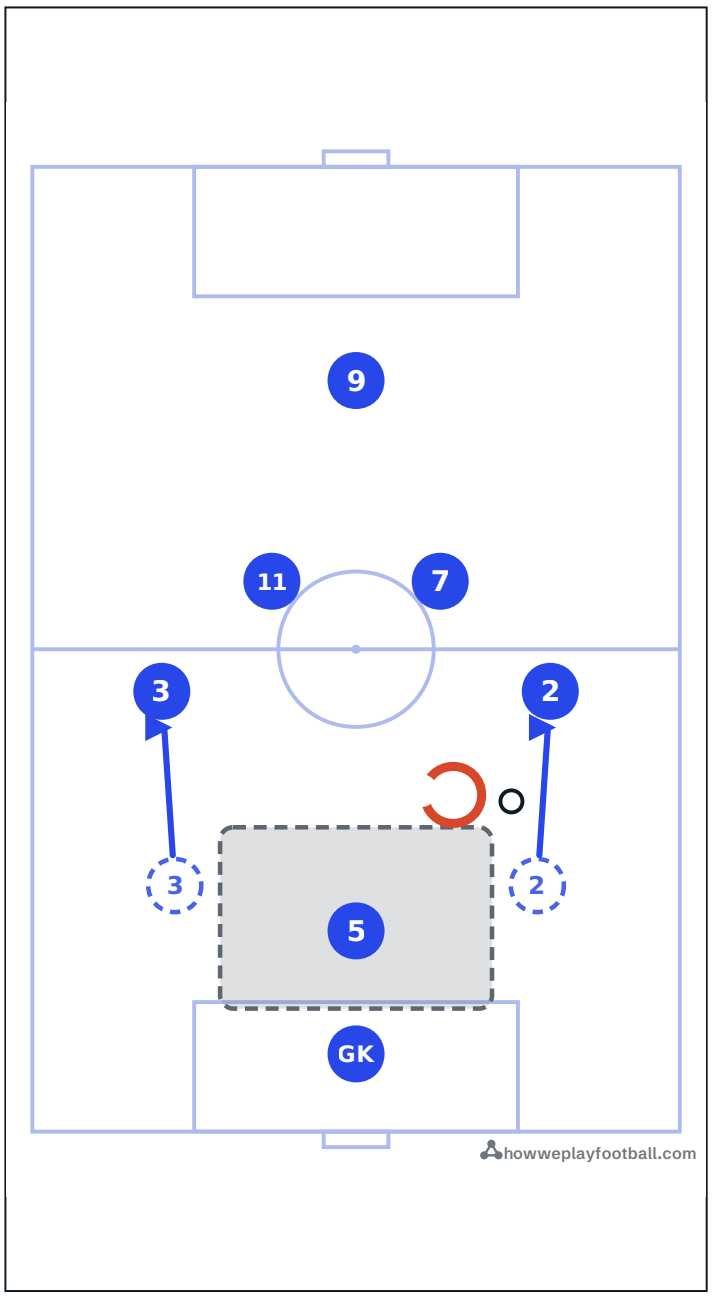
- The goalkeeper looks at the picture before choosing a pass.
- The outside defenders find space that the goalkeeper can see; the centre-back stays available as a middle option.
- If short passes are blocked, the team does not have to force them.

The players can make different choices in different situations. The drawings are illustrative, not fixed moves.

CHAPTER 02 · PRINCIPLE 02 OF 04

ONE GOES, TWO PROTECT

Find width without leaving our centre-back alone. An outside defender can support play on the wing if the other two defenders are ready to protect us.



PICTURE 1 OF 2

BOTH GO: WE'RE OPEN

If both outside defenders race forward, 5 ~~can be left alone to protect our goal.~~

SAY IT ON THE TOUCHLINE

"ONE GOES. WHERE ARE THE OTHER TWO?"

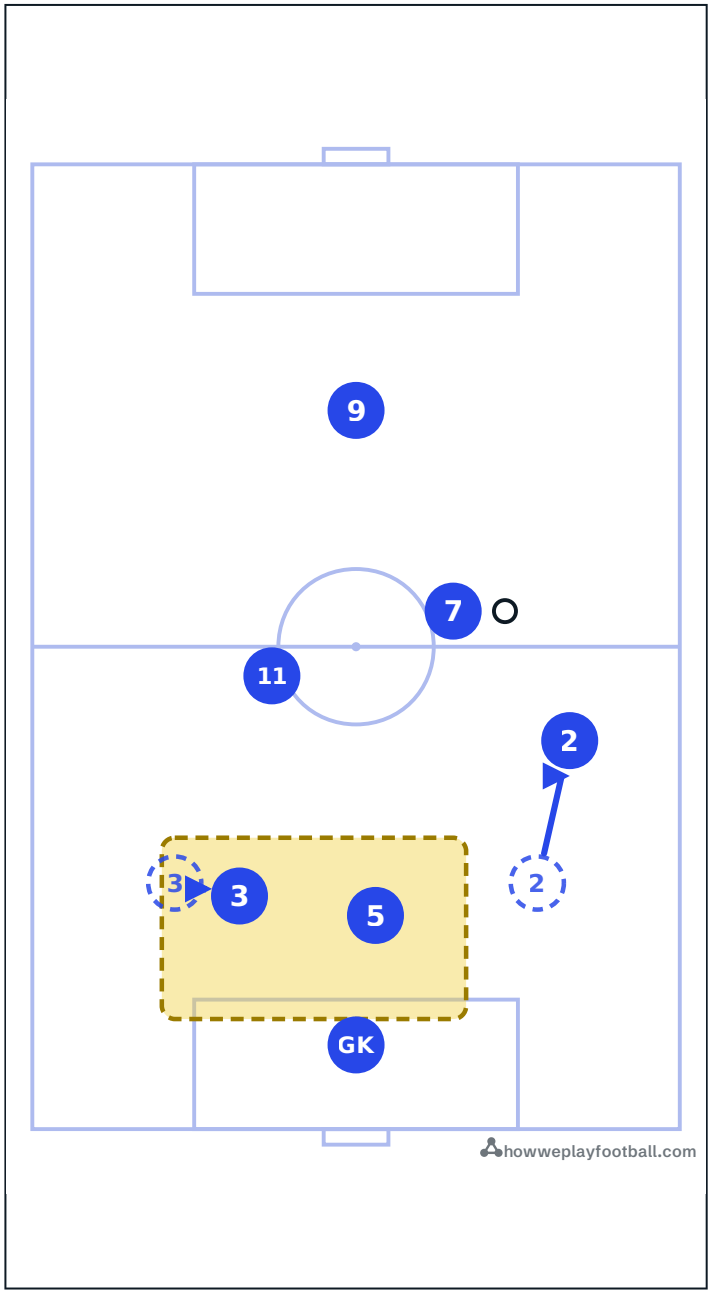
The right and left outside defenders share the responsibility. Which one advances depends on where the ball and safe spaces are.

Move from the first picture to the next to discuss the decision. The drawings are illustrative, not fixed moves.

CHAPTER 02 · PRINCIPLE 02 OF 04

LOOK FOR THIS

Three things to notice when your players make this decision.



PICTURE 2 OF 2

RIGHT GOES. TWO PROTECT.

2 can give us width when the moment is right; 5 and 3 keep the route to goal covered.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

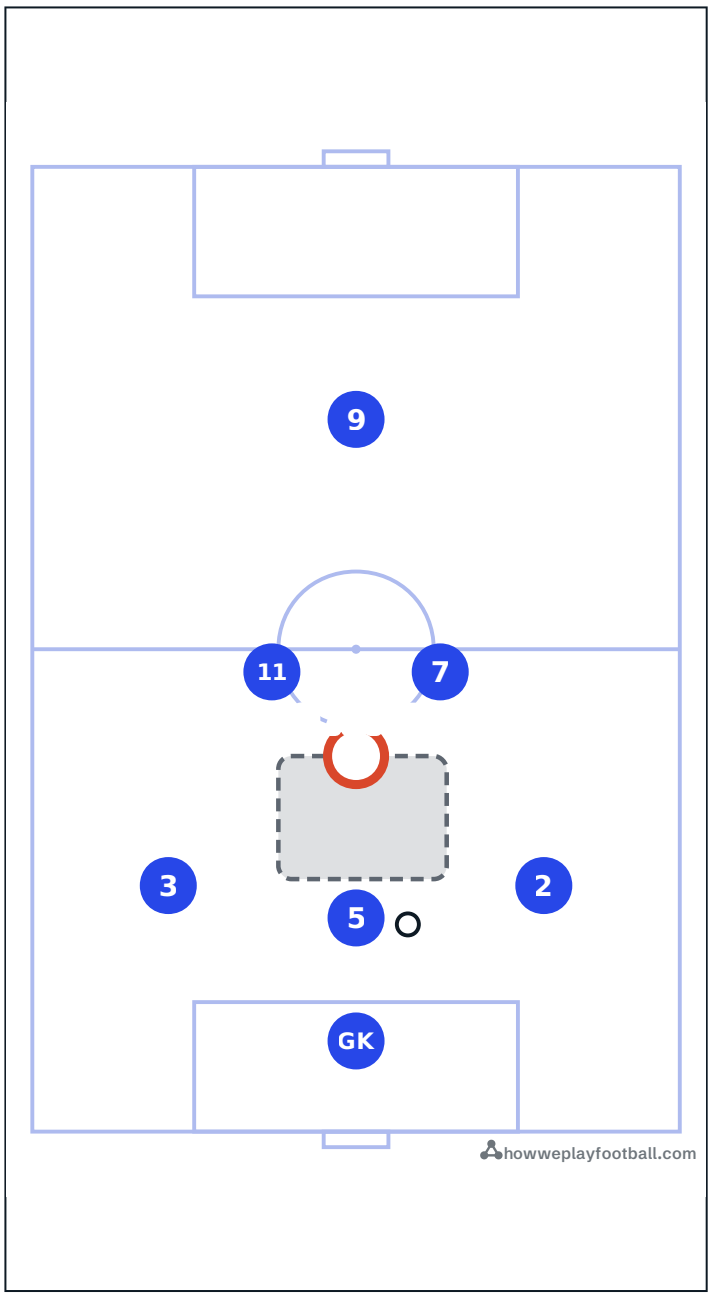
- The outside defender decides whether there is space to support the attack.
- The centre-back and opposite outside defender remain connected and able to defend if the ball is lost.
- The team avoids sending both outside defenders away from the goal at the same moment.

The players can make different choices in different situations. The drawings are illustrative, not fixed moves.

CHAPTER 02 · PRINCIPLE 03 OF 04

ONE SHORT, ONE HIGHER

Two midfielders can give us different passing distances. One midfielder offers a shorter pass while the other can support the striker on a higher line.



PICTURE 1 OF 2

SAME LINE, FEWER OPTIONS

When our two midfielders stand flat, the next pass can become difficult to see.

SAY IT ON THE TOUCHLINE

"CAN WE GIVE TWO DIFFERENT PASSES?"

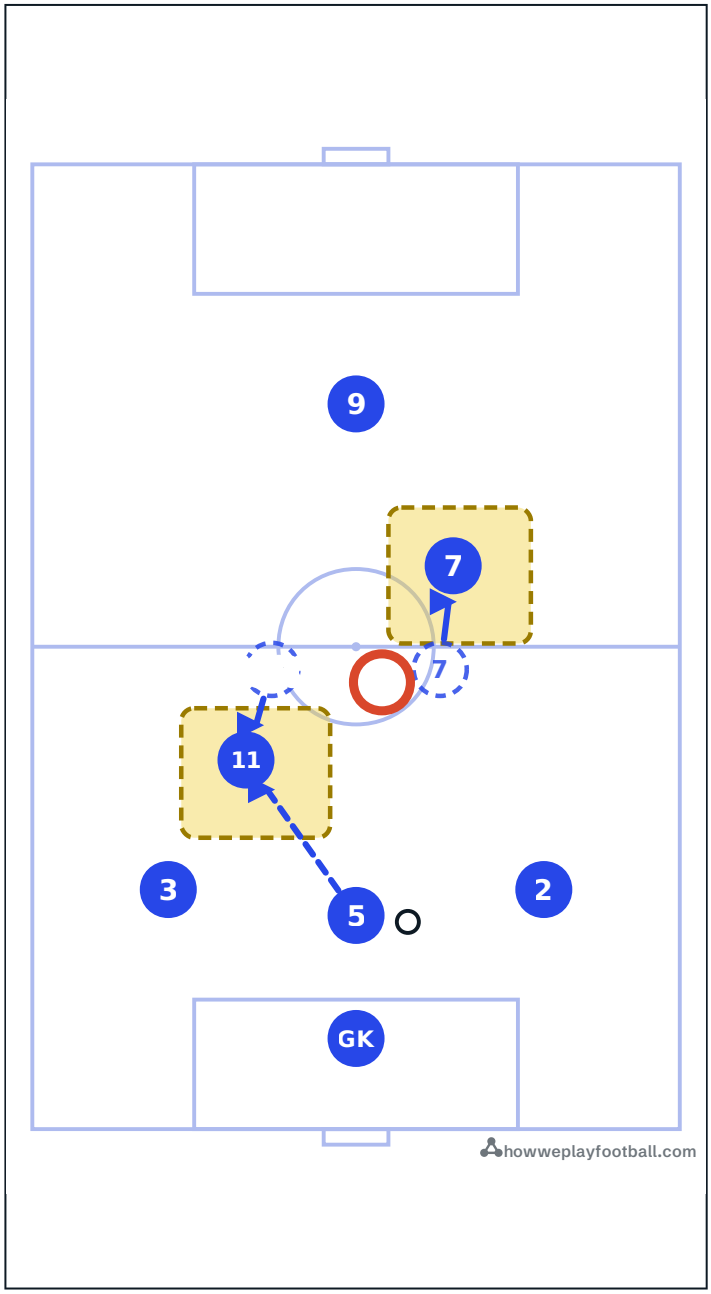
The jobs can switch. This is about seeing space, not assigning one midfielder to stay back forever.

Move from the first picture to the next to discuss the decision. The drawings are illustrative, not fixed moves.

CHAPTER 02 · PRINCIPLE 03 OF 04

LOOK FOR THIS

Three things to notice when your players make this decision.



PICTURE 2 OF 2

ONE SHORT. ONE HIGHER

11 offers a closer pass while 7 gets into a different space nearer our striker.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

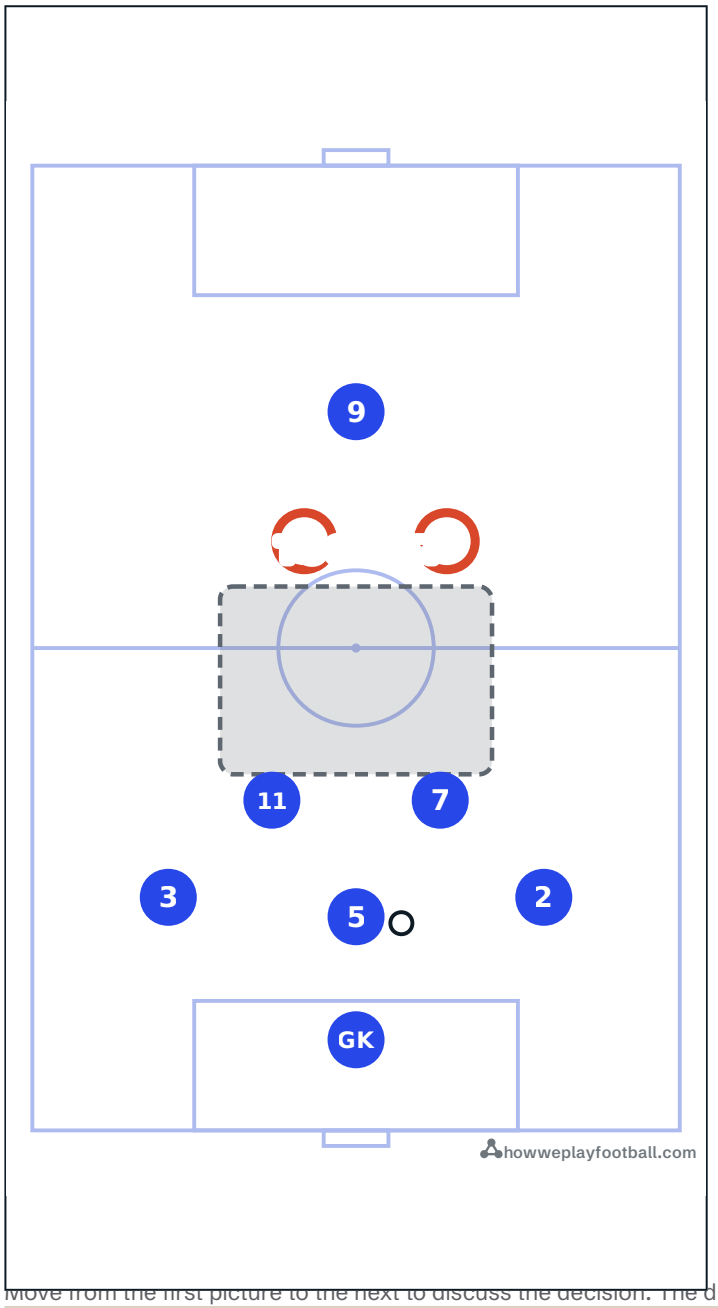
- If both midfielders are on the same line, one can move to help the player on the ball.
- The other looks for a different space further forward rather than following the first player.
- Both recover to help the back three when we lose possession.

The players can make different choices in different situations. The drawings are illustrative, not fixed moves.

CHAPTER 02 · PRINCIPLE 04 OF 04

DON'T LEAVE NINE ALONE

Give our striker somebody to play with. One midfielder moves near enough to link with the striker, with another option behind and the defenders connected.



PICTURE 1 OF 2

NINE NEEDS HELP

If both midfielders stay deep, our striker can end up too far away to combine.

SAY IT ON THE TOUCHLINE

"WHO'S CLOSE ENOUGH TO HELP NINE?"

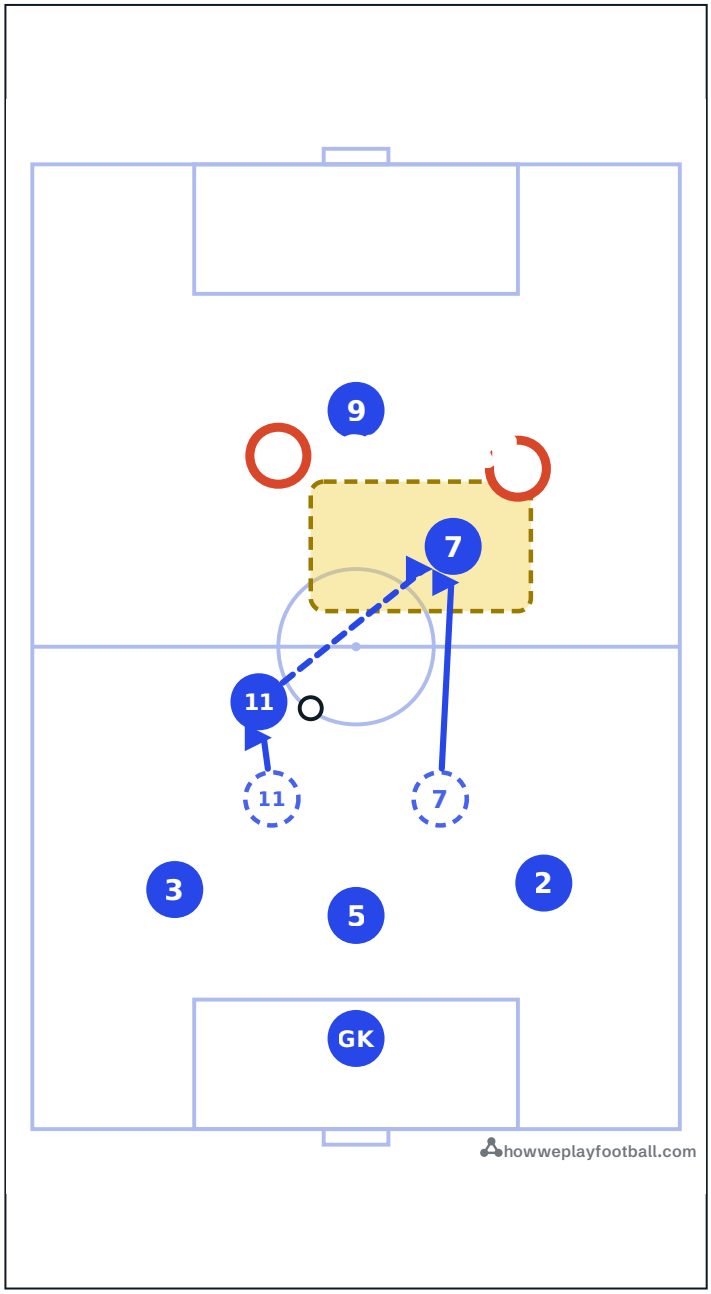
Sometimes our nine shows for the ball, sometimes they stretch the pitch. The team should offer support in either picture.

Move from the first picture to the next to discuss the decision. The drawings are illustrative, not fixed moves.

CHAPTER 02 · PRINCIPLE 04 OF 04

LOOK FOR THIS

Three things to notice when your players make this decision.



PICTURE 2 OF 2

GET NEAR AND GIVE OPTIONS

11 joins the attack to support 9; 11 stays available for the next pass and our back three remain connected.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

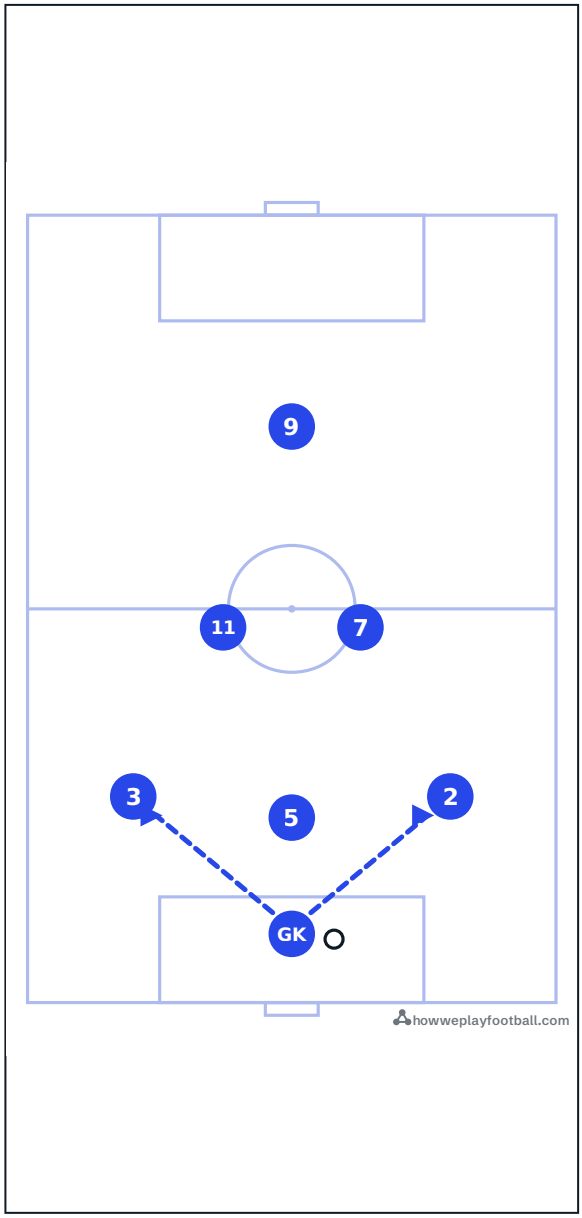
- Check whether our striker is too far from both midfielders to combine.
- One midfielder can move to support while the other remains a short or safe passing option.
- Players behind the ball keep enough balance to respond if possession is lost.

The players can make different choices in different situations. The drawings are illustrative, not fixed moves.

CHAPTER 03 · A JOB FOR EVERY PLAYER

GK GOALKEEPER

Look first. Give us a start.



YOUR JOBS

- Before restarting, look for a safe pass to the centre-back or either outside defender.
- Use the space and time you have; don't force a short pass when it is not there.
- Stay ready behind the three defenders and share clear, calm information when we defend.

ASK YOURSELF

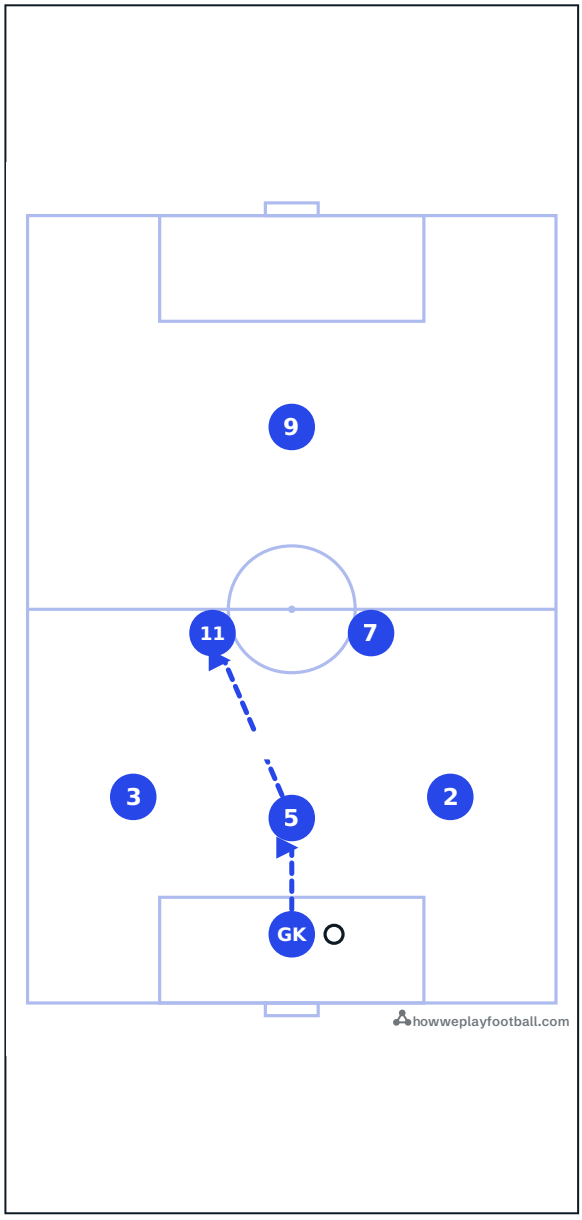
"WHICH PASS CAN I ACTUALLY MAKE?"

A starting job, not a fixed position for the whole game.

CHAPTER 03 · A JOB FOR EVERY PLAYER

5 CENTRE-BACK

Connect and protect



YOUR JOBS

- Be available as a passing option through the middle when the goalkeeper or defenders have the ball.
- Look for a simple pass to a midfielder when the path is clear.
- If an outside defender steps forward, help protect the central route to our goal.
- Talk to the other two defenders so the back three stays connected.

ASK YOURSELF

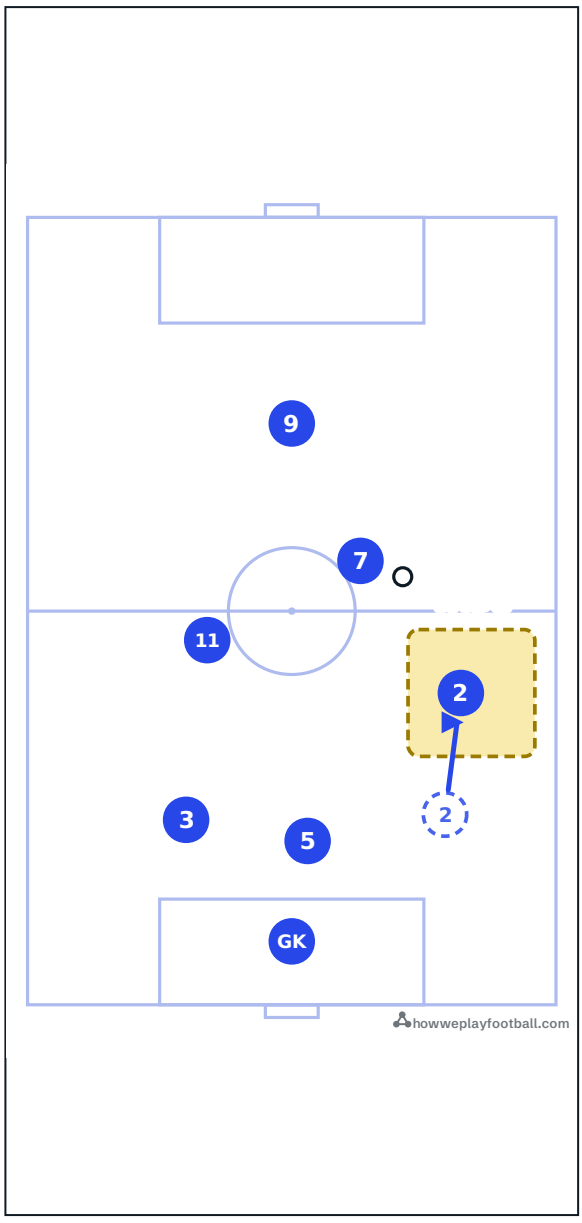
"IS THE MIDDLE PROTECTED?"

A starting job, not a fixed position for the whole game.

CHAPTER 03 · A JOB FOR EVERY PLAYER

3 · 2 OUTSIDE DEFENDERS

Defend your side. Know when to join in.



YOUR JOBS

- Give our goalkeeper and centre-back a passing angle rather than hiding behind an opponent.
- Look for a chance to support the team in wide space when our cover is ready.
- When the other outside defender goes forward, recover towards the centre-back to help protect the goal.

ASK YOURSELF

- Don't both chase forward at once; respond to the call of your teammates.

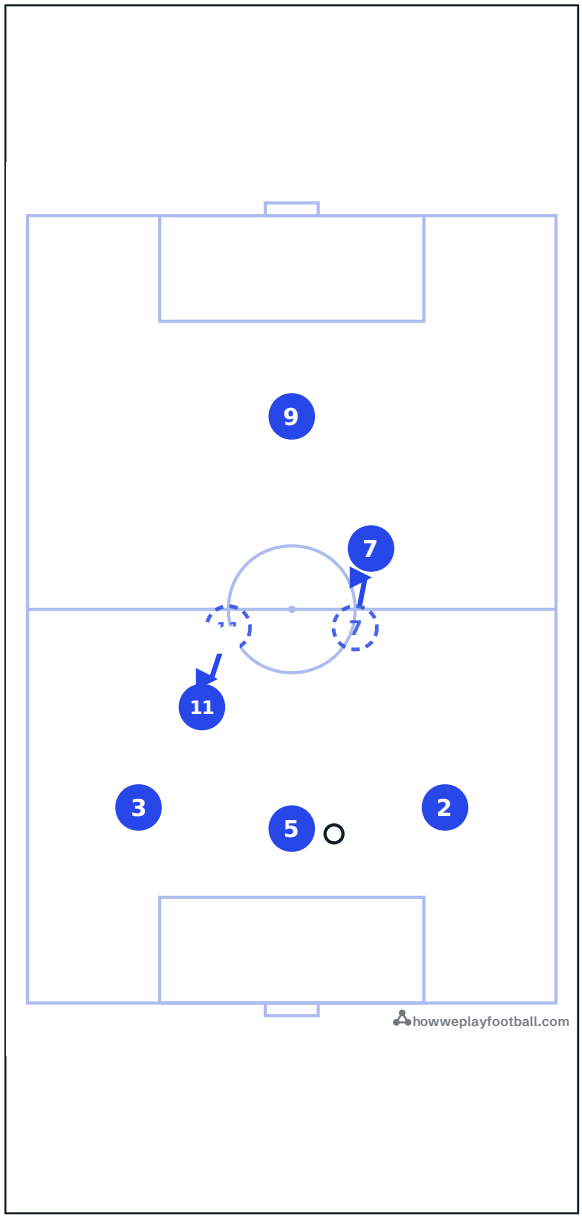
"SHOULD I GO, OR AM I THE COVER?"

A starting job, not a fixed position for the whole game.

CHAPTER 03 · A JOB FOR EVERY PLAYER

11 · 7 THE TWO MIDFIELDERS

Different angles, together



YOUR JOBS

- Try not to stand flat together: one can offer a short pass while the other looks further forwards.
- Share the job of supporting our striker instead of leaving them isolated.
- Find different spaces to receive when the back three are in possession.
- Recover towards the middle to help defend when we lose the ball.

ASK YOURSELF

- Should one be higher and deeper? Does that help players learn different decisions?

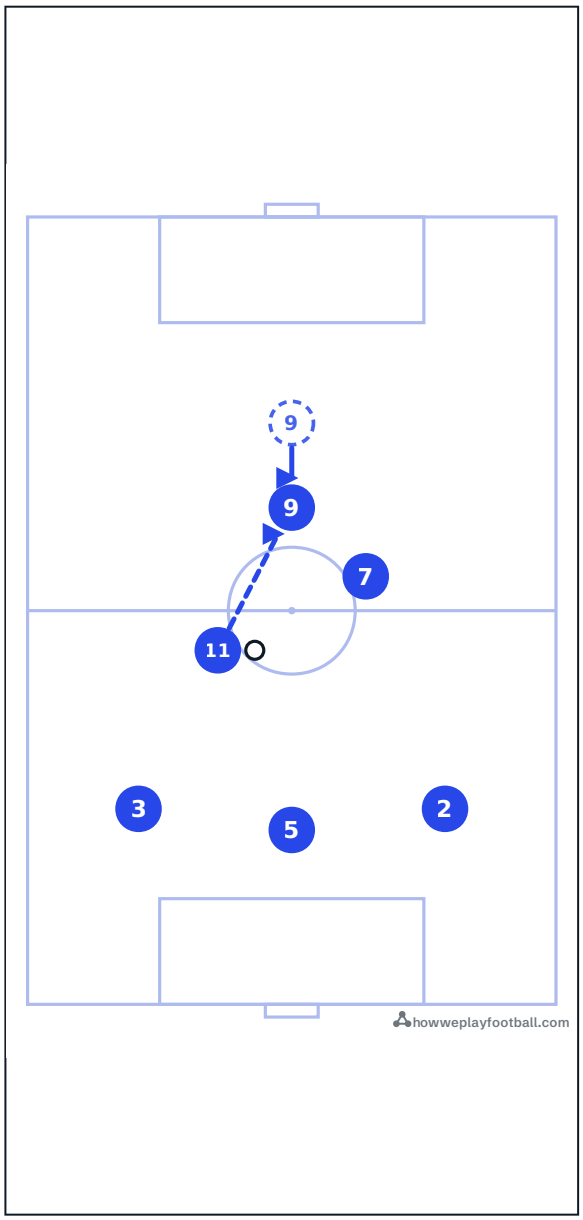
"WHERE IS MY PARTNER? WHAT CAN I OFFER?"

A starting job, not a fixed position for the whole game.

CHAPTER 03 · A JOB FOR EVERY PLAYER

9 STRIKER

Show short or stretch the pitch



YOUR JOBS

- Give teammates an option ahead when they want to play forwards.
- Sometimes come towards the ball to receive a short pass.
- Other times threaten the space behind the defenders to make room for teammates.
- Look for a supporting midfielder; you aren't expected to attack alone.

ASK YOURSELF

- Before you receive, see if the next pass is open. If not, reposition so you can start with the ball, without chasing everything.

"DO WE NEED A SHORT PASS OR SPACE AHEAD?"

A starting job, not a fixed position for the whole game.

CHAPTER 04 · PLAYING AS A TEAM

PLAYING TOGETHER

A formation only works when players make decisions with each other, with and without the ball.

WHEN WE HAVE THE BALL

PRINCIPLE 1

USE THE BACK THREE

A centre-back and two outside defenders help create different passing angles when the ball starts with our goalkeeper.

PRINCIPLE 2

ONE GOES, TWO PROTECT

An outside defender can support play on the wing if the other two defenders are ready to protect us.

PARTNERSHIP · 3 AND 2

OUTSIDE DEFENDERS

Defend your side. Know when to join in.

WHEN WE LOSE THE BALL

PARTNERSHIP · 5

CENTRE-BACK

Connect and protect

PARTNERSHIP · 3 AND 2

OUTSIDE DEFENDERS

Defend your side. Know when to join in.

CONNECTING TO THE STRIKER

PRINCIPLE 3

ONE SHORT, ONE HIGHER

One midfielder offers a shorter pass while the other can support the striker on a higher line.

PRINCIPLE 4

DON'T LEAVE NINE ALONE

One midfielder moves near enough to link with the striker, with another option behind and the defenders connected.

PARTNERSHIP · 11 AND 7

THE TWO MIDFIELDERS

Different angles, together

CHAPTER 04 · KEEP IT SIMPLE

COACHING REMINDERS

All four principles and the player questions in one place.

FOUR PRINCIPLES

01 USE THE BACK THREE
“Can our keeper see a pass?”

02 ONE GOES, TWO PROTECT
“One goes. Where are the other two?”

03 ONE SHORT, ONE HIGHER
“Can we give two different passes?”

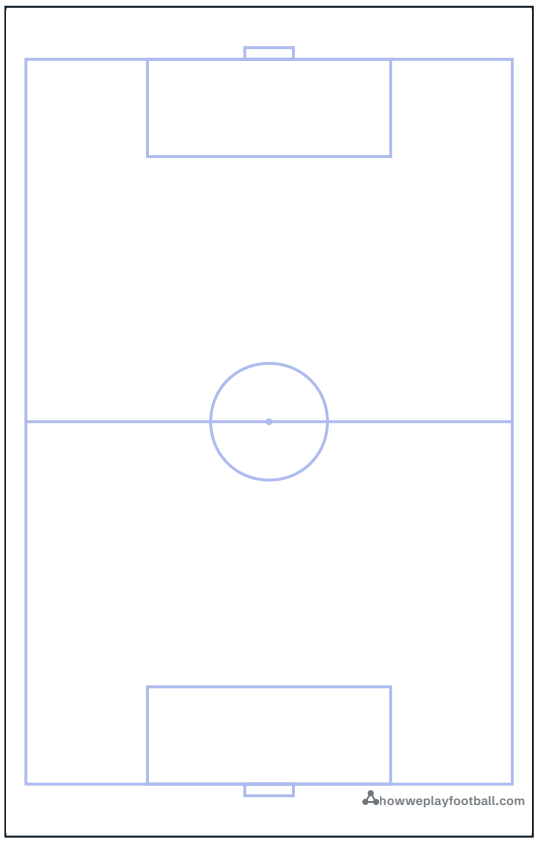
04 DON'T LEAVE NINE ALONE
“Who's close enough to help nine?”

A QUESTION FOR EVERY PLAYER

GK	Goalkeeper	**Which pass can I actually make?**
5	Centre-back	**Is the middle protected?**
3 · 2	Outside defenders	**Should I go, or am I the cover?**
11 · 7	The two midfielders	**Where is my partner? What can I offer?**
9	Striker	**Do we need a short pass or space ahead?**

YOUR NOTES

NOTES



KEEP GOING ONLINE

EXPLORE MORE FREE GUIDES

howweplayfootball.com

More grassroots football guides, illustrated principles and help for coaches at every stage.

SCAN FOR THE ONLINE GUIDE

THE 3-2-1 ONLINE

Explore the full guide with animated tactical diagrams.

howweplayfootball.com/formations/7v7/3-2-1/

FOLLOW HOW WE PLAY FOOTBALL

INSTAGRAM
@howweplayfootball

TIKTOK
@howweplayfootball

YOUTUBE
@howweplayfootball

HOW WE PLAY FOOTBALL

Helping your team take the next step.

How We Play Football is an independent project. It is not affiliated with or endorsed by The FA or England Football. Original diagrams © How We Play Football.